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The new face of defense
tech — Ethan Thornton of
Mach Industries — takes
the AI Stage at
TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

Autonomous weapons, decentralized strategy, and startup speed — this isn't the future of defense, it's the now. At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), Ethan Thornton, CEO and founder of Mach Industries, steps onto the [AI Stage](#) to talk about how next-gen defense is being built from the ground up with AI at its core.

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Founder & CEO,
Mach Industries

Inside the AI arms race — and the founder aiming to rewrite it

[Ethan Thornton](#) isn't your typical defense industry leader. As the CEO and founder of Mach Industries, he launched the company out of MIT in 2023 with a bold mission: to build decentralized, next-generation defense technologies that can safeguard freedom on a global scale.

Now leading one of the most ambitious startups in the space, Thornton is bringing a fresh perspective to an industry dominated by legacy players. His

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work blends frontier hardware, software, and autonomy to rethink how nations defend themselves in a rapidly changing world.

From startup lab to battlefield impact

[Mach Industries](#) is part of a new wave of companies proving that AI-native startups can play a critical role in national defense. This session will unpack what that means in practice — from autonomous systems and edge computing to dual-use technologies that blur the lines between commercial innovation and military capability.

Hear from Thornton on navigating funding, regulation, and responsibility at the intersection of tech and geopolitics.

AI isn't just powering chatbots — it's redefining global power

With global tensions rising and investment in defense tech accelerating, this conversation offers an urgent and timely look at how artificial intelligence is reshaping security, strategy, and sovereignty. [Register now to save up to \\$675](#) before prices go up next week, and be in the room with 10,000+ startup and VC leaders shaping the next era of innovation.

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Wayve CEO Alex Kendall brings the future of autonomous AI to TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 8:15 AM PDT · July 8, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

WAYVE / ALEX KENDALL CEO, WAYVE

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) hits Moscone West in San Francisco from October 27–29, bringing together more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders for a deep



dive into the future of technology. One of the most compelling conversations on one of the AI Stages will feature a panel of innovators redefining what intelligent systems can do. Among them is [Alex Kendall](#), co-founder and CEO of Wayve.



From research breakthrough to real-world autonomy

Kendall founded [Wayve](#) in 2017 with a bold vision: to unlock autonomous mobility, not through handcrafted rules but through embodied intelligence. His pioneering research at the University of Cambridge laid the foundation for a new generation of self-driving systems powered by deep learning and computer vision. Under his leadership, Wayve became the first to prove that a machine could learn to interpret its surroundings and make real-time driving decisions — without relying on traditional maps or manual coding.

Today, Kendall is leading the charge toward AV2.0, an entirely new architecture for autonomous vehicles that is designed to scale globally. As CEO, he focuses on aligning strategy, research, partnerships, and commercialization to bring intelligent driving systems to the road. With a PhD in computer vision and robotics, award-winning academic work, and recognition on the Forbes 30 Under 30 list, Kendall is a rare blend of scientist, founder, and industry operator.

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What to expect on the AI Stage

While full panel details are still under wraps, Kendall's participation ensures that this session will offer more than just theoretical takes. Expect insights on how embodied intelligence can shift the trajectory of AI, the challenges of building systems that adapt to the real world, and what it takes to commercialize autonomy at scale.

Catch Alex Kendall live on one of the two [AI Stages at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27–29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. The exact session timing to be announced. [Register here](#) to join more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders and **save up to \$675** before prices increase.

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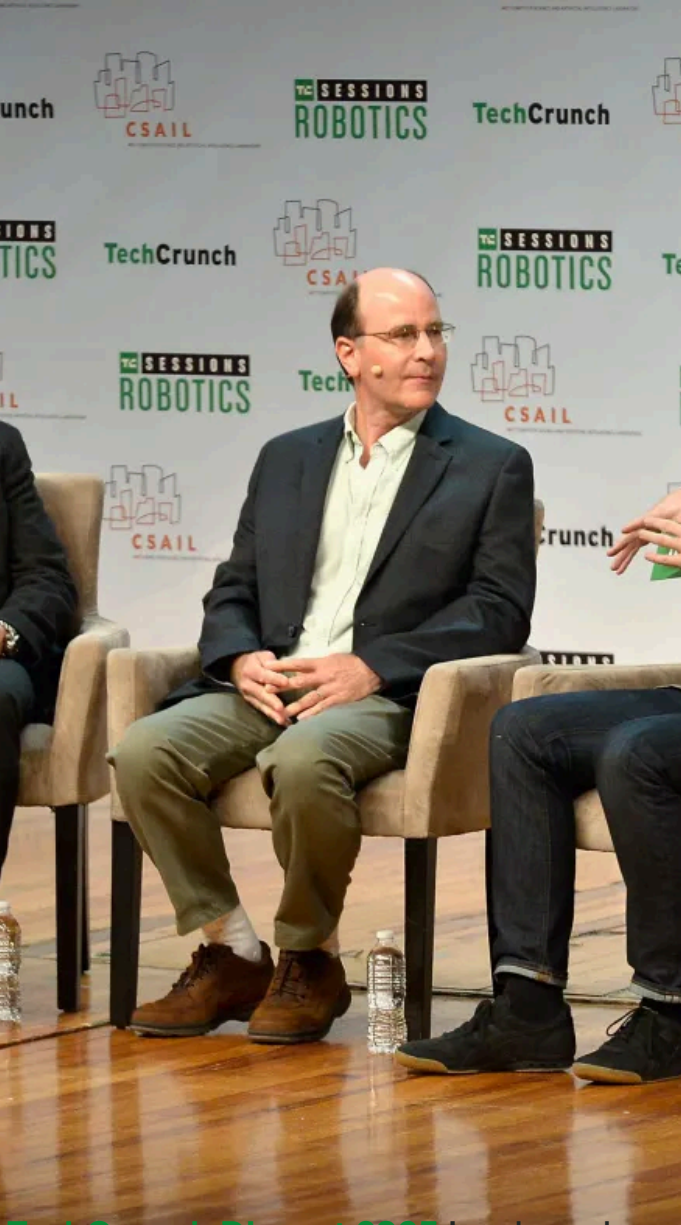
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AI



National security meets next-gen tech at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025's AI Defense panel

TechCrunch Events — 8:00 AM PDT · July 22, 2025

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 is where breakthrough ideas meet the real-world challenges that define the future — and with over 10,000 startup and VC leaders converging, there's no better place to have the hard conversations. One of the most urgent? How artificial intelligence is reshaping national defense, security, and critical infrastructure in real time.

Enter **AI Defense**, a can't-miss panel discussion taking place on one of the two AI Stages, where leaders from government, venture, and the armed services will explore the high-stakes collision of innovation and national security.

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Why this conversation matters now

With AI evolving at a blistering pace, the stakes for defense innovation have never been higher. From autonomous systems and decision intelligence to cybersecurity and battlefield readiness, the U.S. defense and intelligence communities are racing to build smarter, more adaptive technologies — without compromising ethics, oversight, or safety.

[This panel](#) explores the delicate balance between intelligence and control, the role of startups in defense innovation, and the multibillion-dollar opportunities emerging at the intersection of national security and AI.

If your startup touches defense, government, cybersecurity, or AI infrastructure, this is a conversation you can't afford to miss.

Where defense, intelligence, and innovation converge

Onstage, you'll hear from [Dr. Kathleen Fisher](#), director of the Information Innovation Office at [DARPA](#), who is leading the charge on tech that gives the U.S. and its allies an edge in the information wars of the 21st century. With a career that spans



AT&T Labs and academia at Tufts University, Fisher blends research credibility with strategic vision, and she's shaping the next generation of defense-grade AI.

Joining the panel is [Sri Chandrasekar](#), managing partner at [Point72 Ventures](#), and formerly a leader at In-Q-Tel, the CIA's strategic investment arm. Chandrasekar knows how to spot frontier tech that moves the needle, and he's built investment frameworks to support some of the intelligence community's toughest missions.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

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Rounding out the panel is [Justin Fanelli](#), chief technology officer for the Department of the Navy. Fanelli lives at the intersection of cybersecurity, innovation, and adoption, driving digital transformation across one of the most complex organizations in government. From his DARPA Service Chiefs Fellowship to his nationally recognized work in defense health and command

systems, Fanelli brings the boots-on-the-ground perspective to how defense is done in the age of AI.

Catch it live at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

This **AI Defense** panel takes place on the [AI Stage](#).
Exact session time coming soon — but don't wait to claim your pass.

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 runs October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. Join 10,000+ startup and VC leaders for three days of conversations and connections that define what's next. [Grab your pass now before prices increase after July.](#)

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